

Academic Presentation Skills: Structure and Signposting

Lecture Notes — Nanjing University of Science & Technology

January 2026

1 A Standard Academic Structure

A successful academic presentation typically follows a logical 7-step progression:

1. **Title & Context:** Paper title, authors name, affiliation.
 - *Contexts:* Conference, course, seminar, workshop, lecture, etc.
2. **Introduction (Why this matters):**
 - Background (macro) and specific context.
 - Research gap, problem, or question.
 - Purpose, scope, focus, and significance of the study.
3. **Literature / Theoretical Framework (brief):**
 - Key studies or theories; research gap; your position.
 - Address: **what** has been studied, **how** it was approached, **what is missing**, and where **your study** stands.
4. **Methodology (How you did it):**
 - Data/materials, methods/approach, and justification (why this method?).
5. **Results / Analysis (Core part):**
 - Key findings only; use tables, graphs, and examples.
 - **Highlight patterns**, do *not* just present raw data.
6. **Discussion (What it means):**
 - Interpretation of results; relation to research question; comparison with previous studies.
7. **Conclusion:**
 - Main takeaways (2–3 points), contributions, limitations, and brief future research directions.

2 Identifying Signposts

Definition: Words or expressions indicating the connections between sentences and paragraphs.

2.1 Functions and Applications

Signposts enhance comprehension and help the audience make predictions. They are widely applied to:

- Make a list / Show sequence
- Shift topics / Add information
- Provide examples / Clarify viewpoints
- Show cause & effect

2.2 Key Signposting Phrases

To Contrast & Compare

Contrast: but; yet; although; however; nonetheless; on the other hand; in contrast to; nevertheless.

Compare: similarly; likewise; in comparison with; similar to; correspondingly; equally.

Example: **Similarly**, if you have food allergies, you should always ask what is in the dish.

To Give an Example

for example; for instance; to illustrate; as an illustration; one/an example; as can be seen by; in other words; namely; specifically; a typical case in point is...; to be specific...

Example: **A case in point** was the controversy provoked by the agitation for full payment.

3 Slide Design: Academic but Readable

Dos	Don'ts
• One idea per slide • Bullet points, not paragraphs • Use figures instead of text where possible • Consistent font and layout	• Reading slides word for word • Dense text • Decorative animations